



LINE OF DUTY

A RAGPICKER goes about his business as policemen stand guard during a rally organised by the BJP against rising prices in the capital recently. Inflation or not, it was business as usual at the bottom of the heap for this boy.

SUVASHIS MULLICK/www.indiatodayimages.com



KOLKATA | Street Smart

Hawkers are set to make a return to the city, this time with the Left Front Government's blessings. Five years ago, the then sports minister Subhas Chakraborty had taken it upon himself to rid the city of street vendors, having them evicted in a drive called Operation Sunrise. Almost two lakh street vendors lost their livelihood selling goods as diverse as toys, fruits and vegetables and clothes. Now, with the civic body elections round the corner, the state Government has decided to give the streets back to the hawkers in an obvious election ploy. The government has also decided to give pattas at Rs 1 each for 99-year leases to slum-dwellers in the state, which spells good news for illegal migrants. Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee is mum on the developments; given the poverty line, she cannot be seen or heard screaming against land and business prospects for patta holders and hawkers.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

ALLOWING HAWKERS BACK INTO THE CITY IS AN ELECTION PLOY BY THE LEFT FRONT AHEAD OF THE CIVIC BODY POLLS.